

[Skip to main content](#)[r/GooglePixel](#) ×

Search in r/GooglePixel



Create



r/GooglePixel • 1y ago

Kunzite_



Google Ruined My Wife's Pixel 4a, Offered Compensation, and Then Made It Useless... Here's the Story

Hey r/GooglePixel,

I'm not super Reddit-savvy, but I don't know where else to go. I need to share my wife's frustrating experience with Google's recent Pixel 4a "Battery Performance" update. You know, the one where Google forced an update that bricked her perfectly good phone and then gave her \$100 credit as "compensation"? Well, buckle up, because it gets worse.

Here's what happened:

1. The Issue: Like many others, my wife's Pixel 4a was essentially ruined after Google's mandatory forced update. Google's handling of this update has created waves of frustration across its user base. Battery life? Toast. Usability? Gone. Her once-reliable phone was rendered useless.
2. The "Fix": Google offered \$100 store credit to use toward a new Pixel device. Fine, we thought—not ideal, but at least it's something, right?
3. The Catch: We went to the Google Store to buy a Pixel 8a that was already on sale. But when we tried to redeem the \$100 credit, the system wouldn't let us... because the phone was "already discounted."

Let me say that again: Google gave my wife \$100 credit because they broke her phone... but won't let her use it to buy the replacement device because it's on sale. The sale price has nothing to do with the situation—this is supposed to be compensation, not a coupon!

1. Google's Support Response: We reached out to customer support (full transcript here: <https://imgur.com/a/w3uBueZ>). We explained that this isn't a typical promo code—it's a voucher to make up for their forced update ruining her phone. After being bounced around and asked to "try incognito mode" (seriously?), they ultimately said they couldn't help us. When we attempted to further explain the situation, they abruptly disconnected the chat without resolving anything.

The excuse? "Promo codes cannot be combined with other promotions." But nowhere in the terms does it say that this credit can't be used on a sale item. Even worse, others have apparently been able to use their vouchers on discounted phones. Why the inconsistency?

1. Adding Insult to Injury: If she had chosen the \$50 cash option instead of the \$100 store credit, she wouldn't have been restricted like this. The \$100 store credit is essentially Google saying, "We're sorry for ruining your phone, but please consider buying a Pixel again." Yet when we try to, they make it as difficult as possible.
2. Even Worse: To add fuel to the fire, we're now seeing reports from others who, after being refused the ability to use their store credit, are also being denied the option to go back and choose the \$50 cash alternative. So not only is the credit worthless in many cases, but once you've picked it, you're stuck with it.

My Takeaway: This "compensation" is essentially worthless if my wife can't use it to buy the replacement phone it's meant for. Google's update broke her phone, and now they're nickel-and-diming us on their so-called solution. It's insulting.

Here's the simple solution Google should offer:

[Skip to main content](#)[+ Create](#)

phone. What that means is that they're not going to give you a direct replacement.

I wanted to share this here because:

- Awareness: If you're dealing with the same issue, you're not alone.
- Advice: If anyone's successfully navigated this nonsense, I'd love to hear how you did it.
- Accountability: Google needs to know this isn't okay. Their lack of support is unacceptable, and they need to do better.

Let's make some noise. If you've dealt with this or have thoughts, drop them in the comments. Google, if you're reading this: Fix this mess.

We've fallen in love with Pixel devices over the years because they've been so reliable. We've purchased several Pixels, trusting Google to deliver great products. But now, Google has destroyed that trust with how they're handling this issue. It's heartbreaking to see a brand we believed in let its loyal customers down.



Archived post. New comments cannot be posted and votes cannot be cast.

719

178



1

[Share](#)Sort by: **Best** ▾[🔍 Search Comments](#)[+ \[deleted\]](#) • 1y ago[chazjamie](#) • 1y ago

Blow them up on twitter. Bbb. Etc. I went through something similar. Eventually I got a new phone. It took a very long time. It was mind numbing. Because it wasn't one or two posts I made. It was like 5 a day.

[nugstar](#) • 1y ago • Edited 1y ago

Pixel 4 XL

This. I did the same, once you cost them more in wages for CS to deal with, they'll send you a refurb phone.

[+ 1 more reply](#)[Tough_Variety_7143](#) • 1y ago

When I had this happen a couple of years ago, I created summary like you did , looked up emails of the Google executives/managers for pixel, put them on the To line and tech journalists on the CC line. They sent me replacement phone in 24 hours.



[Skip to main content](#)[Create](#)**bryanus** • 1y ago

If your pixel 6a can be bootloader unlocked, you can revert to the last build prior to the update that doesn't have the battery "fix" and get your 4a working again. Sneaky Google removed all of the previous builds from their site, but they are available on different sources and backups. See this post:

<https://www.reddit.com/r/Pixel4a/s/9UPaXFry8h>

Google is a POS for doing this. They've done this before as well. In 2018 I had an old Nexus streaming player that received an update and then suddenly bricked itself. It's still an open "[bug](#)"

Then more recently (last summer) I did a factory restore of my pixel 6a after immediately applying an update and it went into a bootloop. This affected thousands (tens?) of 6a owners worldwide, and Google's resolution was to take the device to a ubreakifix shop where they would charge you(!) for a new motherboard. After several chats and emails, I was able to get an "executive resolution" and they replaced my device, but most are SOL.

**[deleted]** • 1y ago**TotalTeacup** • 1y ago

Only thing that makes sense to me is Google being aware of some kind of battery problem, every 4a was a time bomb, so they pulled the plug. Why else issue an update after the 4a had been sunsetted?

**Twitten** • 1y ago

It isn't every 4a.

**Luxferro** • 1y ago

Google always does whatever it can to deny people customer support. The purpose of their customer support is to frustrate people so they stop trying to get help.

[1 more reply](#)**horatiobanz** • 1y ago

Top 1% Commenter

You know the neat thing about this whole Pixel 4a debacle? That no reviewer will mention it in their next Pixel review, because for some reason Google gets a pass from all reviewers on everything. If OnePlus had intentionally bricked an older phone, every single review for the next 5 years, even watch reviews, would have a warning in the "con" column about OnePlus potentially bricking your device.

[Skip to main content](#)[+ Create](#)**FrauWetterwachs** • 1y ago

I'm German so my experience may vary, but I've just gotten my store credit from my old pixel 4a too and bought an already discounted Pixel 8a with 256gb with it - saved over 300€ this way... Doesn't seem to be a problem everywhere (I do hold the new and paid for phone in my hands right now, so I know in fact that everything went fine).

[+ 3 more replies](#)**doug_kaplan** • 1y ago

I currently have an open case with Google where I am demanding some type of proper compensation because when I reached out to them, they said they were able to give me 20% off as additional compensation, but this 20% off is on a non sale price and not able to be stacked with the \$100 credit so to put this into perspective, a \$500 8a would be \$400, which is exactly the same as if I used my \$100 credit or the sale price it was last week.

It's amazing how much Google is messing this up and now my 4a which worked perfectly 2 weeks ago now can barely last an hour on average phone use and is relatively unusable. I know in the T's & C's there is a lot of language around lawsuits or compensation or arbitration but I've never been part of any class action but this time I would happily join because this is pretty ridiculous forcing users to buy a new phone at hundreds of dollars with little to no compensation due to a forced update we had no chance to deny even knowing what harm can come from using this battery in the future.

[+ 2 more replies](#)**[deleted]** • 1y ago

Install a custom rom to the phone like LineageOS

**Jazzlike-Regret-5394** • 1y ago

Banking apps etc. sometimes dont work anymore with custom roms (Play Integrity and SafetyNet bs)

[+ 1 more reply](#)**[deleted]** • 1y ago**seawolf7309** • 1y ago

They probably wrecked it on purpose because 4a was still eligible for lifetime unlimited photo storage.

[Skip to main content](#)

Create



Pixel 10



Top 1% Commenter

Isn't it the pixel 1 that has free unlimited storage?

The other devices had it for a period, it might be free at a reduced size now but it still isn't lifetime unlimited full quality uploads. We all got a notification when it ended with the pixel 6 or 7 release IIRC.



nrq • 1y ago

Pixel 8 Pro

It ended with the 5. Pixel 1 is the only one with original quality uploads, the others still can upload unlimited storage saver quality.



nathderbyshire • 1y ago

Pixel 10



Top 1% Commenter

I thought so. It wouldn't be Reddit without wild accusations though now would it



knofit • 1y ago

Correct if I'm missing context, but I don't believe they said anything about full quality?



nathderbyshire • 1y ago

Pixel 10



Top 1% Commenter

No I brought P1 up because if they were to brick a device due to storage upload they go for that one, not the 4a that doesn't have it, just the basic reduced one like the rest of the pre tensor line which has also been left alone. Or they'd finally crack down on the back methods, but they obviously don't care for one reason or another to do so.

The point is, they said the update was to stop the free photo upgrade when there would be a much more suitable device to do that too, that would make more sense with a much older battery called the OG Pixel, not the 4th gen in and specific to the none 5G variant that came a little later which would also have free upload.

All pre tensor would be nuked if that's the case, which is what makes it a silly and wild accusation



matteventu • 1y ago

Pixel C, 1 XL, 3, 6, 8 Pro, 9 Pro | Pixel Buds Pro Top 1% Commenter

Why just the 4a and not all Pixels from 1 to 5 then?



[deleted] • 1y ago



Zealousideal-Pie-823 • 1y ago

I don't think so. One of their options offered is to replace the battery of the 4a for free, which is what we've opted for, for my father in law's phone.

[Skip to main content](#)[+ Create](#)

The mega corp rot is almost always related to zero resources available and huge bureaucratic roadblocks for the employees who actually really want to fix your problem. Guarantee this is the issue with this situation.

Some bean counters and middle managers do not want to cut a check or spend worker time on dealing with this issue. They have KPIs to hit, or whatever the fuck.

Grand conspiracies in mega corporate structures exist, of course, but they exist at the very top as [backroom cartels](#) and [open corruption](#). I can assure you, Sundar Pichai doesn't know what a Pixel 4a is.

[+ 1 more reply](#)**MargretTatchersParty** • 1y ago

Contact your state's attorney general.

**Satrustegui** • 1y ago

Well mine is also affected aaaaand...

- No battery replacement possible in my country (I live in CZ)
- I could get about 100 bucks discount on a new pixel - but I won't be getting another pixel ever
- Opted for the 50 bucks cash
- It's almost a month and I have not seen the money in my account

Now my phone is doing hilarious things like passing from 20 to 15% battery while writing this post and telling me my battery will last until 04:15 PM when it is already 04:20 - have this on a screenshot, but this community does not allow images.

[+ 2 more replies](#)**Zealousideal-Pie-823** • 1y ago

Google offered to replace the battery on my father in law's Pixel 4a for free. We've sent the phone for the same. Should get it back early next week.

**mildlyfrostbitten** • 1y ago

they'll break the screen and try to charge you to fix it.

**Zealousideal-Pie-823** • 1y ago

Thanks. The phone came back yesterday with the new battery. All perfect.

[Skip to main content](#)

Create



I was impacted by this too. I tried rolling the OS back and it worked but the update will download anyway. I bought a Pixel 9 as replacement from Mintmobile as they have an offer for current or new customers at \$399, which is hard to pass up. Then, with the 4a now as a backup only phone I installed lineageOS, which is based on android 15, and the battery performance is now just as good as it used to be . As part of the OS update I added the mindthegapps package, which gives you the Google apps too.

**Locusts01** • 1y ago

Do you have recommendations for a guide for installing lineageOS? As my 4a is useless anyway it would be a good learning experience

[+ 1 more reply](#)**Ecevits_Ghost** • 1y ago

Yep. The only downside is that the bootloader will then be unlocked, which taints the phone and renders banking apps (and probably Google Pay?) non-working. (at least I couldn't figure out what I needed to do to make them work again).

The good news is that unlimited saver mode photo backups to Google Photos continue to work after you switch to LineageOS!

**pokenguyen** • 1y ago

Pixel 7 Pro

I believe you can modify LineageOS to trick it into thinking it's Pixel 1 phone and enjoy unlimited original backup

[+ 2 more replies](#)[+ 5 more replies](#)**a_b_c_d_e_z** • 1y ago

You just "ok'd" their shady behaviour. Seriously...

**NZpie** • 1y ago

To get the offer in nz you need to start with an imei. When we enter it, it says invalid and there's no further options

[+ 2 more replies](#)**RedditNotFreeSpeech** • 1y ago

[Skip to main content](#)

Create

**arrivederci117** • 1y ago

Pixel 9 Pro XL

I would just trade it in for a Samsung or an iPhone at this point. The S25 is coming out soon, so Samsung probably has some enhanced trade in value for old phones. You probably could get 100 bucks from your 4A for that.

**neuromonkey** • 1y ago

Quite Black

The only thing that will get Google's attention is a class action lawsuit. They've been doing shit like this for a few years, and the only thing that will change that is financial pressure.

**mjbhatt412** • 1y ago

I also applied for 50\$ refund, how much time it will take to credit? Anyone knows??

[+ 1 more reply](#)**Bed-Beard-Beyond** • 1y ago

My last phone was a Pixel 8 Pro - I bought it last year - never again. Worst phone I've ever owned, couldn't get rid of it fast enough. I've since bought a One Plus 13 (which I am very happy with!) and can't sell the Pixel 8 Pro for love nor money

**JustAnotherEnginerd** • 1y ago

Pixel 9 Pro XL

Weird, I guess we were just lucky then.

Then my wife had the same issue with her phone after the mandatory update. Here in Germany she received €120 store credit.

I bought the phone with my account since I currently have the 2 TB Google one subscription active as part of the try Gemini program. Interestingly, I was able to redeem the €120 discount code also on my account.

The phone itself was not discounted but she got the pixel 9 Pro with quite some discounts:

1099€ base price

- 120€ pixel 4 battery issue discount
- 120€ store credit promotion
- ~90€ store credit as part of the 10% cash back

[Skip to main content](#)

Create



...price match, should have been more since Amazon was selling at a loss but they ...

Of course it is questionable if their trade-in partner will still value Pixel 4 at 77 Euros but even with only the 100 Euro trade-in bonus, it's still a pretty good price for a new pixel 9 pro.

8 more replies



sparx_fast • 1y ago

This is why I took the cash. I'm done with Pixel and probably taking a break from Android.

Even getting the \$50 was absurdly convoluted. Requires your SSN/Bank Account and lots of validation with a third party that takes weeks. I'm determined to quit Google for a while though. The more painful they make it, the harder it will be for them to get me back.

1 more reply



PhotojournalistBusy2 • 1y ago

I just reverted back to the previous version (before googles update) and disabled automatic updates in dev options, and DNS filtered/ blacklisted googles OTA updates. My pixel 4a works perfectly now. There's a ton of instructions online and on Reddit etc. No need to buy a new phone



jasikanicolepi • 1y ago

Why would you buy another pixel after the whole pixel 4a shenanigans from the force update. If anything they could do the same again with the 8a. The whole incident would leave a sour taste that I would never buy another pixel device.



AdmiralKarlDonuts • 1y ago

Odd to hear that they didn't allow the two discounts to be combined - I was able to use both.



-Bob-Barker- • 1y ago

Not only did I get sale price and \$100 credit applied but I'm also getting \$120 in return for trading in my now useless 4a.

I don't know why it's not working for you.



WatercressNumerous51 • 1y ago

[Skip to main content](#)

Create



[REDACTED]

1 more reply

**theGekkoST** • 1y ago

Your best bet here is to start an informal dispute as part of the arbitration process. You will deal with someone directly at Google HQ and won't have to deal with support agents in another country anymore.

This matter is trivial to resolve for them and cost way less than arbitration. so they will likely fix the issue for you in the informal dispute process, and it will never get to arbitration.



[deleted] • 1y ago

**Lilybell2** • 1y ago

Did you post about this in the Google Pixel Help Community forum?

<https://support.google.com/pixelphone/community?hl=en&sjid=16649081821148007300-NC>

**TurningTablesAgain** • 1y ago

The pixel community does not help in the slightest anytime there's an actual glaring issue, it's more often than not never answered or immediately shut down because they're trying to save face. It's the same issue that happened with my pixel watch when I made a big post about it and it garnered attention and then they took it down. Support's useless. Honestly, the pixel service as far as support is completely useless

**nathderbyshire** • 1y ago

Pixel 10



Top 1% Commenter

They don't even work for Google do they? They have as much influence as a Reddit mod and are there to answer more basic things and escalate everything else from what I've seen

**Kunzite_** OP • 1y ago • Edited 1y ago

Hi Lilybell. We have not. Thanks for the suggestion! We will give it a try.

Edit: Link to the google support post I just made.

[Google Ruined My Wife's Pixel 4a - Compensation Gone Wrong! - Google Pixel Community](#)

2 more replies

**jaba1337** • 1y ago

[Skip to main content](#)[+ Create](#)**-Bob-Barker-** • 1y ago

did you also get the 4a trade in valued at \$120?



1 more reply



2 more replies

**wickedplayer494** • 1y ago

Pixel 7 Pro

[u/PixelCommunity](#) ?**Khaine123** • 1y ago

Glad I decided to go with the cash, fuck Google, I will not be buying a pixel again despite the current one serving me well until the update.



3 more replies

**[deleted]** • 1y ago

The credit vs discount issue is virtually universal. It's not a Google thing and most stores the world over do business this way. If they did stack just recently and then google rescinded it, it's just adding fuel to the fire and an incredibly PR-dense move in the middle of this whole situation.

It's pitiful how weak even the largest companies can be at what shouldn't be an issue to begin with. Terrible handling and planning. Luckily, humanity stands united for their consumer rights and won't stand for it... If only. :(

**GiraffeDiver** • 1y ago

In my country the 8a is sold via a couple retailers at \$420, but google store offers one for \$590 so the \$100 store credit I got is kind of a joke.

After the update they said I can also choose a free battery replacement, but I already claimed the useless \$100 voucher before they mentioned it as an option. (wish I just took the \$50 cash, but I figured I'll probably get another pixel so the \$100 seemed like more value)

**unitin78** • 1y ago

My take is that P4a was the late of the devices with unlimited high storage backup option and they wanted to get rid of this benefit once and for all. Having said that, why you didn't chose the option to

[Skip to main content](#)

Create

 [1 more reply](#)**Puzzleheaded-Fee-742** • 1y ago

This makes me want to sell my pixel 9 XL and just get the new galaxy....

**globalistnepobaby** • 1y ago**Ecevits_Ghost** • 1y ago

This doesn't in any way excuse Google's behavior, but if the issue was caused by an Android system update, you could just install LineageOS on the phone. I did that with my Pixel 3a a few years ago and it works great (except that banking apps won't work because the bootloader is unlocked). The important thing for me is that Google Photos backups from the device are still unlimited (saver mode, of course) even after replacing the stock Android with LineageOS - I only keep this device around for that reason anyway :-)

**Lilybell2** • 1y ago

The update is designed to address the possibility of a serious battery issue. Switching to a different OS may stop the admittedly annoying stabilization of the battery; however, that will also reintroduce the issue the update was intended to mitigate. Basically, that's like jumping directly from the frying pan straight into the fire.

**Bbarryy** • 1y ago

Why was this downvoted? It is the best remedy.

**Ecevits_Ghost** • 1y ago

Because there are apparent sociopaths roaming [r/tmobile](#) that downvote whatever they don't agree with, or sometimes if a response doesn't exactly answer the original question but instead answers a side question or suggests an alternative (even though it contributes to the conversation). I've noticed this on other people's comments quite a bit, but it's usually a single downvote making it a 0, so I just add my upvote and move on. :-/

**[deleted]** • 1y ago**HelenaR3** • 1y ago

I love Pixel phones but I don't understand why they suddenly die. I had the Nexus 5x, the Pixel 3a and currently have the Pixel 6a, the first 2 died suddenly. We have older phones like an Honor 8 and some



Create



not updated my Pixel 6a, I hate the annoying notification that I need to update it.



[deleted] • 1y ago